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SECURITY



For privacy and security,  
think twice before  
granting AI access to  
your personal data

AI is being forced on us in pretty much every facet of life, from [phones and apps](#) to [search engines](#) and even [drive-throughs](#), for some reason. The fact that we're now getting [web browsers with baked-in AI assistants and chatbots](#) shows that the way some people are using the internet to seek out and consume information today is very different from even a few years ago.

But AI tools are more and more asking for gross levels of access to your personal data under the guise of needing it to work. This kind of access is not normal, nor should it be normalized.

Not so long ago, you would be right to question why a seemingly innocuous-looking free “flashlight” or “calculator” app in the app store would try to request access to your contacts, photos, and even your real-time location data. These apps may not need that data to function, but they will request it if they think they can make a buck or two [by monetizing your data](#).

These days, AI isn't all that different.

Take [Perplexity's latest AI-powered web browser, Comet](#), as an example. Comet lets users find answers with its built-in AI search engine and automate routine tasks, like summarizing emails and calendar events.

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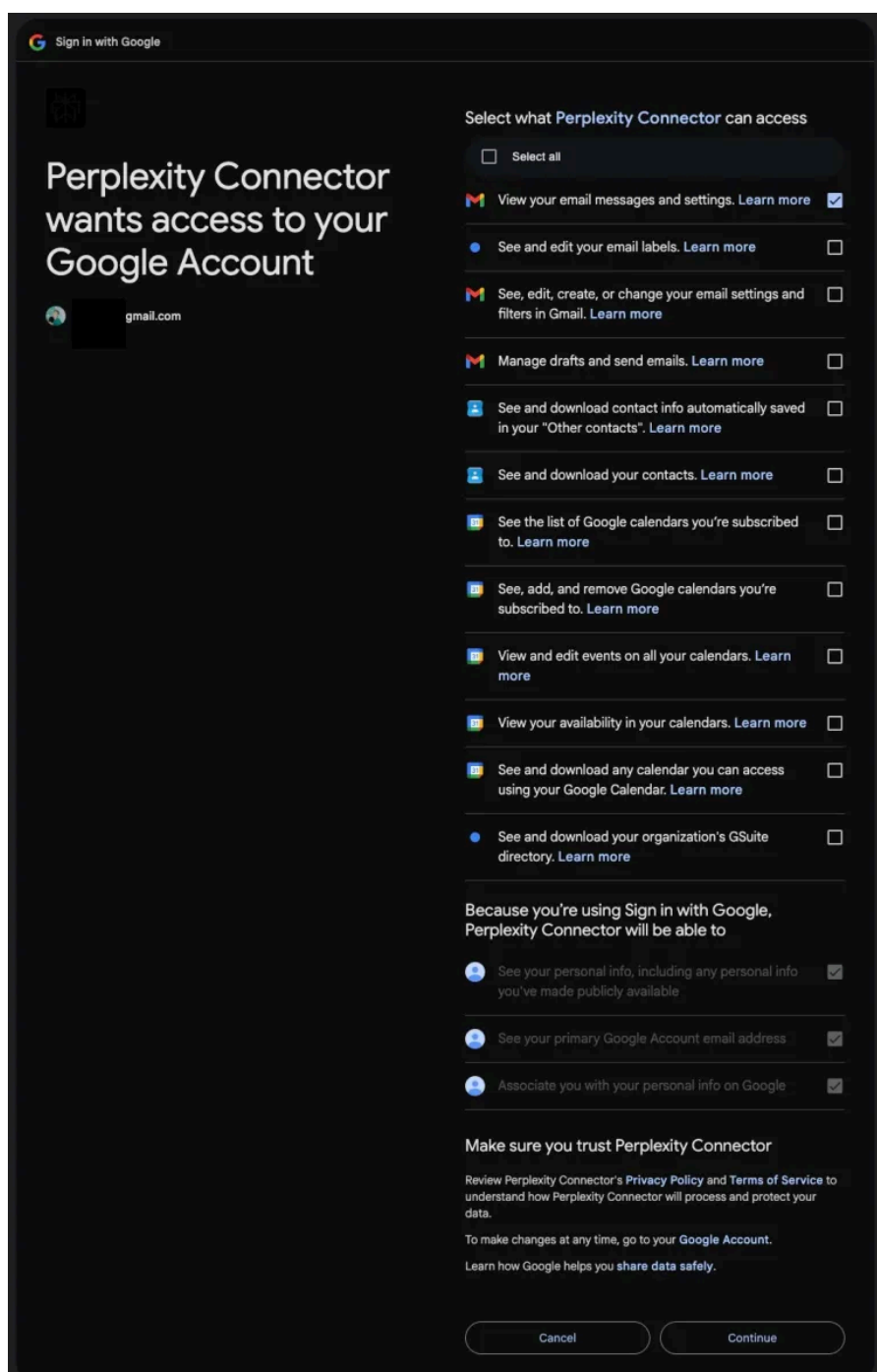
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In a recent hands-on with the browser, TechCrunch found that when Perplexity requests access to a user's Google Calendar, the browser asks for a broad swath of permissions to the user's Google Account, including the ability to manage drafts and send emails, download your contacts, view and edit events on all of your calendars, and even the ability to take a copy of your company's entire employee directory.

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COMET'S REQUESTED ACCESS TO A USER'S GOOGLE ACCOUNT  
IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

Perplexity says much of this data is stored locally on your device, but you're still granting the company rights to access and use your personal

information, including to improve its AI models for everyone else.

Perplexity isn't alone in asking for access to your data. There is a trend of AI apps that promise to save you time by transcribing your calls or work meetings, for example, but which require an AI assistant to access your real-time private conversations, your calendars, contacts, and more. Meta, too, has been testing the limits of what its AI apps can ask to access, including tapping into the [photos stored in a user's camera roll](#) that haven't been uploaded yet.

Signal president Meredith Whittaker [recently likened](#) the use of AI agents and assistants to “putting your brain in a jar.” Whittaker explained how some AI products can promise to do all kinds of mundane tasks, like reserving a table at a restaurant or booking a ticket for a concert. But to do that, AI will say it needs your permission to open your browser to load the website (which can allow the AI access to your stored passwords, bookmarks, and your browsing history), a credit card to make the reservation, your calendar to mark the date, and it may also ask to open your contacts so you can share the booking with a friend.

There are serious security and privacy risks associated with using AI assistants that rely on your data. In allowing access, you're instantly and irreversibly handing over the rights to an entire snapshot of [your most personal information](#) as of that moment in time, from your inbox, messages, and calendar entries dating back years, and more. All of this for the sake of performing a task that ostensibly saves you time — or, to Whittaker's point, saves you from having to actively think about it.

You're also granting the AI agent permission to act autonomously on your behalf, requiring you to put

an enormous amount of trust in a technology that is already prone to [getting things wrong](#) or [flatly making things up](#). Using AI further requires you to trust the profit-seeking companies developing these AI products, which [rely on your data to try to make their AI models perform better](#). When things go wrong (and they do, a lot), it's common practice for humans at AI companies to look over your private prompts to figure out why things didn't work.

From a security and privacy point of view, a simple cost-benefit analysis of connecting AI to your most personal data just isn't worth giving up access to your most private information. Any AI app asking for these levels of permissions should send your alarm bells ringing, just like the flashlight app wanting to know your location at any moment in time.

Given the reams of data that you hand over to AI companies, ask yourself if what you get out of it is really worth it.

Topics: [agentic ai](#) [AI](#) [Analysis](#) [cybersecurity](#)

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**Zack Whittaker**

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IMAGE CREDITS: GETTY IMAGES

SECURITY



## Even the FBI says you should use an ad blocker

Zack Whittaker — 8:20 AM PST · December 22, 2022

This holiday season, consider giving the gift of security with an ad blocker.

That's the takeaway message from an unlikely source — the FBI — which this week issued an alert warning that cybercriminals are using online ads in search results with the ultimate goal of stealing or extorting money from victims.

In a pre-holiday [public service announcement](#), the FBI said that cybercriminals are buying ads to impersonate legitimate brands, like cryptocurrency exchanges. Ads are often placed at the top of

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from loading in your browser, including in search results. By blocking ads, would-be victims are not shown any ads at all, making it easier to find and access the websites of legitimate brands.

Ad blockers don't just remove the enormous bloat from websites, like auto-playing video and splashy ads that take up half the page, which make your computer fans run like jet engines. Ad blockers are also good for privacy, because they prevent the tracking code within ads from loading. That means the ad companies, like Google and Facebook, [cannot track you](#) as you browse the web, or learn which websites you visit, or infer what things you might be interested in based on your web history.

The good news is that some of the best ad blockers out there are free, and can be installed and largely forgotten.

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If you're looking for a widely recommended ad blocker, uBlock Origin is a simple, low-memory ad blocker that works for most browsers, like [Google Chrome](#), [Mozilla Firefox](#), [Microsoft Edge](#) and [Opera](#), plus the [extension is open source](#) so anyone can look at the code and make sure it's safe to run.

You can also get content blockers for Android and iOS, which block ads from loading on your device.

Of course, you can switch your ad blocker off any time you want, and even allow or deny ads for entire websites. Ads are still an important part of what keeps the internet largely free and accessible, including TechCrunch, even as subscriptions and paywalls are increasingly becoming the norm.

While you're here, if an ad blocker sounds right for you, consider [these other web browser extensions](#) and features that make browsing the web safer and more private.



# How to browse the web privately and securely



Cybersecurity 101: These tips and features will help preserve your security and privacy.



Topics: [ad blockers](#) [cybersecurity](#) [online advertising](#)

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KEEP READING

SECURITY



VPN providers don't protect your privacy

# online. Here's what can.

Zack Whittaker — 9:00 AM PDT · September 30, 2024

If you've heard that a VPN provider can help protect your privacy and security online, [don't believe the hype](#). The truth is that [most people don't actually need a VPN](#).

By funneling all of your internet traffic through their own servers, VPN providers expose their customers to the very privacy risks they claim to help defend against, including having their internet browsing records stolen by cybercriminals or obtained by legal order.

IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN / TECHCRUNCH

That's why if you [think you need a VPN](#), we'll show you how to [set up your own private and encrypted VPN server](#).

If you're in the majority who don't need to use a VPN, there are still easy and effective ways to reduce the trail of data that you leave behind as you browse the web. Some of these ways include the use of simple tools in your browser that can automatically prevent online trackers from collecting information about you to begin with, and encrypting your web browsing traffic that makes it more difficult for anyone to snoop on the sites and services you access.

There are no one-size-fits-all solutions or a panacea for absolute privacy. Instead, all of these

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### SECURITY



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Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

simple steps can provide additional and meaningful privacy as you use the web, and we'll explain how.

# Install and use an ad-blocker

Love them or hate them, ad blockers are an important security and privacy defense for any online user. Even [the FBI suggests using an ad blocker](#), given the rise of malicious ads used for scams, fraud, and [the delivery of malware and spyware](#).

[Ad blockers](#) are web browser extensions that automatically prevent ads from loading on websites and in search results. The obvious upside is that your visual browsing experience will improve, but ad blockers also stop your browser loading the underlying tracking code that ads rely on to collect information about you. By blocking the code, ad companies can't track the websites you visit as you browse the web, which makes it more difficult for the ad and tech companies to infer your tastes and interests and otherwise monetize your browsing data. (Of course, you can always temporarily switch off your ad blocker on any website.)

Using an ad blocker is one of the most effective ways of preventing the majority of online tracking by making it much more difficult for advertising and tech giants to know which websites you visit as you browse the web.

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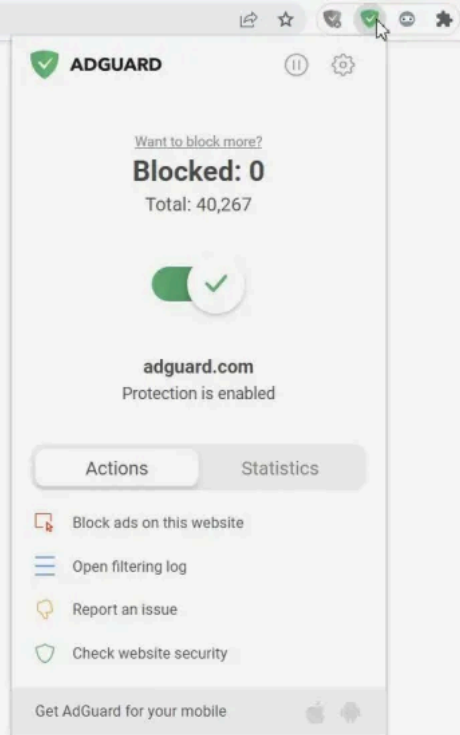


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AN AD BLOCKER PREVENTS ADS — AND THEIR PRIVACY-INVADING TRACKING CODE — FROM LOADING ON WEBSITES AND IN SEARCH RESULTS.

IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH (SCREENSHOT)

One of the best low-memory ad blockers for web browsers is [uBlock Origin](#), which works in most modern browsers, and its code is open source (allowing anyone to look at the source code to make sure it's safe to use). [AdGuard](#) also has an [open source](#) ad blocker for a variety of devices and platforms. Remember to always download from trusted and verified sources, like their official pages, before installing.

Once you're set up with an ad blocker, the online rights group Electronic Frontier Foundation has a tool called [Cover Your Tracks](#) that lets you stress-test your browser's anti-tracking defenses and tells you what you can do to help improve them. This other [online open source tool](#) is an easy way to quickly test your ad blocker on any device.

## Use an encrypted DNS provider

Almost every website on the internet today can be delivered to your browser over an encrypted connection (known as HTTPS), which prevents anybody else on the internet from seeing what loads on your screen or tampering with it before it gets there.

But because of the way that the internet inherently functions and routes your information around the world (through a public and global system called DNS), you can still leave behind a record of the specific website you visited because DNS traffic has historically largely been unencrypted.

For most, your unencrypted DNS traffic — which can reveal which websites you're visiting and the apps you're using — typically routes through your internet provider, which, like advertisers and tech giants, can monetize and sell that data or make your information available to requesting legal authorities.

Switching to an encrypted DNS service is fairly quick and simple, and it can have immediate effect.

Some browsers (like [Chrome](#) and [Firefox](#)) began encrypting DNS traffic by default back in 2020, and have long included options to use an encrypted DNS provider, such as Cloudflare and NextDNS, to handle DNS traffic instead of your local internet provider.

You should be aware of how long the provider retains your information; some of the large DNS providers [provide reasonable security and privacy assurances](#). Also, if your DNS provider briefly goes down, your internet activity will suffer until the problem resolves or you switch your DNS provider. This is also why picking a reputable DNS provider can be helpful.

You can go beyond just your browser’s settings by changing your DNS in the settings for your device, so that all of the DNS traffic on your device gets encrypted. If you want all the devices on your home network to take advantage of encrypted DNS, you can opt to change the DNS settings on your network router, too.

## A multi-hop service, like Apple Private Relay, can have privacy benefits

A core problem with VPNs is that you have to trust a single provider that it won’t sell or snoop on your data, or provide it to someone who will. Since 2021, Apple has allowed its paying customers to stay more private online through its “multi-hop” service called [iCloud Private Relay](#), which sends a user’s encrypted internet traffic through two separate internet relays (or “hops”), including one that isn’t run by Apple.

Because iCloud Private Relay uses two separate internet relays to route a user’s traffic, this prevents either of the internet relays, including Apple, from being able to see or analyze your internet traffic. That also means that requesting law enforcement authorities cannot get your information from a single internet relay; they instead have to demand the data from both relays. Apple’s partners, [like Cloudflare](#), help to provide the multi-hop relay service.

ICLOUD PRIVATE RELAY HIDES YOUR BROWSING ACTIVITY IN SAFARI  
AND OTHER APPS TO PREVENT SNOOPING ON YOUR WEB TRAFFIC.

IMAGE CREDITS:TECHCRUNCH (SCREENSHOT)

iCloud Private Relay helps to protect both web and app traffic on your Apple device, and is available for Apple customers who pay for Apple’s premium iCloud+ service. iCloud Private Relay isn’t available in all regions, such as countries like China and Russia, where internet freedoms are considerably limited.

While services like iCloud Private Relay offer some privacy benefits, beware of non-reputable providers that purport to offer multi-hop services or make other claims that cannot be independently verified.

## Tor is the gold standard for online anonymity

Wherever you are in the world, using Tor is one of the universally best tools for allowing users to browse the web freely while bypassing censorship and avoiding surveillance.

For some people, Tor is synonymous [with the “dark web,”](#) which some automatically (and wrongly)



conflate with criminality. In reality, Tor is a privacy tool used every day by journalists, researchers, activists, and anyone else who wants to browse the web with a high degree of privacy and anonymity.

You might want to browse the web anonymously for *any* reason, but this can include searching the web without wanting the search engine (or anyone else) connecting you to those search results, or simply accessing a news website or resource that might be banned by a government or regional authority.

*THE BBC NEWS WEBSITE, WHICH IS ACCESSIBLE THROUGH THE TOR BROWSER. THE DARK WEB DOESN'T HAVE TO SEEM SCARY.*

IMAGE CREDITS:TECHCRUNCH (SCREENSHOT)

Instead of relaying your data through a single virtual tunnel (like a VPN) or through two separate relays (like a multi-hop service), Tor works by encrypting and routing its users' internet traffic multiple times through thousands of servers set up around the world. This way, the user's internet traffic is shielded from everyone else on the network as well as the regular internet. As such, using Tor is often slower than the regular internet and is not designed to be used for accessing high-bandwidth services, like music or video streaming.

Most people use Tor by [downloading and running the Tor Browser](#), a custom-made version of Firefox, in which anything that happens in that browser

window privately routes over the Tor network. Other implementations of Tor are available, including mobile apps.

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